AUTHOR'S NOTE

When I was first approached to write this book, the idea was that it would feature seventy-five 'makers of modern India' in order to commemorate India's seventy-fifth year of independence. But before I could dive into research, I had to answer a few questions for myself, starting with 'what is modern India'? And who counts as one of its 'makers'?

In answer to the first question, I took modern India to mean the independent nation-state of India that came into being on 15 August 1947 after decades of nationalist struggle against British colonial rule.

Next, I had to identify who the 'makers' of this modern India were. I was struck by the fact that although the subcontinent had a history going back thousands of years, the democratic nation that was created at Independence was an entirely new thing. It was an idea that brought together (for the first time) a bewildering variety of people with very different experiences into a single political unit. India's 'makers', therefore, were the people who helped shape the former colony into a cohesive and independent nation, and gave it a new identity in terms of its politics, borders, culture, society and economy.

But I immediately ran into difficulties because of the sheer number of people who were involved in nation-building. To me, it seemed like modern India would not be what it is without the contributions of the hundreds, even thousands of people who built and ran institutions, dictated government policy and pushed for social reform. But trying to include all or even most of them would have resulted in a very long, very thick book that would probably have taken me decades to complete.